

SHRINKING WORLD

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UNTIL THE 1940S, AIR TRAVEL was a growing but marginal alternative to travel by ship and train. By 1957, however, more people were crossing the Atlantic by plane than by boat. The triumph of jet airliners in the following decade carried the transformation of travel patterns to a new level. People made journeys they would never previously have made to places they would never have visited. Boeing executive Tex Boullioun said in 1983, "Great cities and great resorts now stand in places where neither ship nor train could have caused them to be." While passenger flight became commonplace – without losing, for some people, associations of anxiety – thousands of individuals recovered the early excitement of flight by piloting their own aircraft or experimenting with small but technologically sophisticated flying machines.



LINING UP FOR TAKEOFF

By the year 2000, more than four million people worldwide were taking to the air every day. The familiar scene of airliners lining up for takeoff at a busy airport was the natural result of technological progress that had made flight fast, safe, reliable, and affordable.